
CHAPTER ONE — STUDY GUIDE

What Is the Septuagint?

A course companion to "The Septuagint: What It Is and Why It Matters"

(Lanier & Ross)

Covers the lecture "What Is the Septuagint" · Corresponds to pp. 25–37 of the textbook

Overview

This module introduces the term *Septuagint* and explains why it doesn't have one single, agreed-upon meaning. You'll learn the four common ways the term is used, how "the Old Greek" differs from "the Septuagint," what the Masoretic Text is and where it comes from, why the Dead Sea Scrolls changed the conversation, and two mistakes ("ditches") to avoid when thinking about all of this.

Four Ways "Septuagint" Has Been Used

Per pages 25–37 of the textbook, the term has been used in increasingly narrow ways:

USAGE	WHAT IT REFERS TO
1 General usage	Any Greek translation of the Jewish scriptures, without firm boundaries.
2 The great uncials	The book-collections found in the great majuscule (uncial) manuscripts — Vaticanus, Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus. Note: these three manuscripts don't fully agree on which books to include, so this usage is still somewhat vague.
3 The Pentateuch	Only the first five books of Moses — Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy.
4 Pentateuch + oldest translations	The five books of Moses, plus the oldest Greek translations of the rest of the Hebrew Bible. This is the sense used throughout this course.

The Old Greek

"The Old Greek" is a related but distinct term you'll see in scholarly literature. It refers to the **oldest surviving Greek translation of any given book** of the Old Testament / Jewish scriptures. For example, whatever the earliest Greek translation of the Book of Haggai was, that translation is what scholars call "the Old Greek of Haggai."

The Hebrew Bible We Inherited

The Masoretic Text

Most modern Old Testament translations are based on the **Masoretic Text** — the mainstream Hebrew text tradition that has come down to us. Its earliest, most complete manuscripts are the **Aleppo Codex** and **Codex Leningrad**, dating to roughly 900–1000 AD and later.

The Masoretes

The Masoretic Text is named for the Masoretes, a group of scholars who began their work around 500 AD and continued for centuries afterward. As Hebrew was dying out as a spoken language, they added a system of dots and dashes beneath the Hebrew consonantal text — the **niqqud** — to preserve correct pronunciation. Their work was a major achievement in preserving the text, even though the text they were copying predates both their manuscripts and the Masoretes themselves by a long time.

The Dead Sea Scrolls

Before the Dead Sea Scrolls were discovered at Qumran in the 1940s, the Masoretic Text was essentially "the only game in town" for Hebrew text. The scrolls revealed something significant: **more than one form** of the Hebrew Bible was circulating in the ancient world.

Some scrolls — like the Great Isaiah Scroll — agree very closely with the Masoretic Text as we have it today, which is often cited in apologetics. But other scrolls differ from the Masoretic Text in real ways.

"But others differ from the Masoretic Text in non-trivial ways — at both the micro level, specific words or phrases, and the macro level, larger differences in the arrangement or length of books."

— Lanier & Ross, The Septuagint: What It Is and Why It Matters

This complicates the idea that "the Septuagint" is simply a Greek translation of "the Hebrew Bible" — because more than one Hebrew Bible was in circulation when the Greek translations were being made.

Two Ditches to Avoid

1. Oversimplification

The Septuagint was never one neat, bound volume — that idea came much later. Translation began around **250 BC**, starting with the Pentateuch (likely in Alexandria, Egypt), with other books translated over a longer period afterward. Treating "the Septuagint" as a single, homogenous translation project misrepresents how it actually came together.

2. Denialism

Some claim there was "no such thing as a Septuagint" in the time of Jesus and the apostles. That's true only if "Septuagint" means a neatly bound single volume — it's false if it means there were no Greek translations of the Hebrew Bible circulating at that time. In fact, some New Testament quotations from Jesus and the apostles align more closely with these Greek translations than with the Masoretic Text.

How this course uses the term

Throughout this course, "Septuagint" refers to the Jewish scriptures as they've come down to us in Greek — both the Pentateuch and the oldest translations of the rest of the Hebrew Bible — while avoiding both oversimplification and denialism.

Key Terms Glossary

Septuagint

Broadly, the Jewish scriptures as they come down to us in Greek; more narrowly, the Pentateuch plus the oldest Greek translations of the rest of the Hebrew Bible.

Old Greek

The oldest surviving Greek translation of a given Old Testament book.

Masoretic Text

The mainstream Hebrew text tradition underlying most modern Old Testament translations, preserved by the Masoretes.

Masoretes

Jewish scholars who, from roughly 500 AD onward, copied and added vowel-pointing (niqqud) to the Hebrew biblical text.

Niqqud

The system of dots and dashes added beneath Hebrew consonants to indicate vowel sounds and aid pronunciation.

Uncials / Majuscules

Ancient Greek manuscripts written in capital letters, including Codex Vaticanus, Codex Sinaiticus, and Codex Alexandrinus.

Dead Sea Scrolls

Ancient Hebrew (and other) manuscripts discovered at Qumran beginning in the 1940s, revealing textual diversity in the Hebrew Bible predating the Masoretic Text.

Pentateuch

The first five books of Moses: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy.

Discussion Questions for Live Session

Twelve questions to guide the live discussion for this chapter.

- 1** Before this lecture, what did you assume "the Septuagint" meant? How has that assumption been complicated or refined?
- 2** Of the four ways "Septuagint" has been used, which one do you think is most useful for everyday reading of Scripture — and which is most useful for scholarly precision? Why might those be different?
- 3** Why do Vaticanus, Sinaiticus, and Alexandrinus disagreeing on which books to include make the "great uncials" definition of Septuagint still somewhat vague?
- 4** What's the difference between "the Septuagint" and "the Old Greek" of a particular book? Why does that distinction matter?
- 5** Why might it matter for your own Bible reading that the Masoretic Text's earliest complete manuscripts (Aleppo Codex, Leningrad Codex) date from roughly 900–1000 AD — centuries after the events they describe?
- 6** What problem were the Masoretes solving when they added the niqqud, and why was that problem urgent at the time?
- 7** Before the Dead Sea Scrolls were discovered, the Masoretic Text was "the only game in town." How did that discovery change the picture?
- 8** The Great Isaiah Scroll agrees closely with the Masoretic Text, while other Dead Sea Scrolls manuscripts differ from it in real ways. How do we hold both of those facts at once?
- 9** In your own words, explain the "oversimplification" ditch. Where have you seen this assumption show up — in a sermon, a book, or a conversation?
- 10** In your own words, explain the "denialism" ditch. Why might someone be tempted toward this position, and what's the more accurate alternative?
- 11** The lecture notes that some New Testament quotations from Jesus and the apostles align more closely with Greek translations than with the Masoretic Text. What are the implications of that for how we think about which "Old Testament" the New Testament authors were reading?
- 12** Given everything in this chapter, how would you now define "Septuagint" in one or two sentences if a friend asked you what it means?

Facilitator note: aim for roughly 5–7 minutes per question if using the full set live; trim to your highest-priority 6–8 questions for a shorter call.